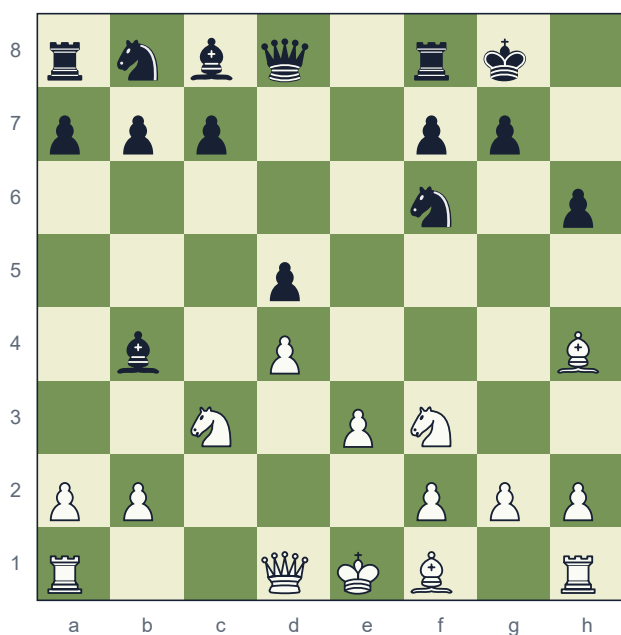


QGD alternatives: Ragozin, Vienna and early deviations

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Keep a coherent answer when Black declines to enter your Exchange setup. Resolve the specific pin or central capture before continuing normal development.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

These variations can produce a Carlsbad, an isolated queen pawn, or a broad e4-d4 center. The pawn skeleton must guide your choice, not the opening name.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

...Bb4 pins Nc3; ...dxc4 can invite e4 and attack the new center; ...a6 prepares ...b5 or asks a useful waiting question.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Against a pin, count whether the pinned piece still defends the center.
2. Recapture a gambit pawn when it helps development; do not chase it with the queen unnecessarily.
3. The move e4 is stronger when its central support survives an exchange.

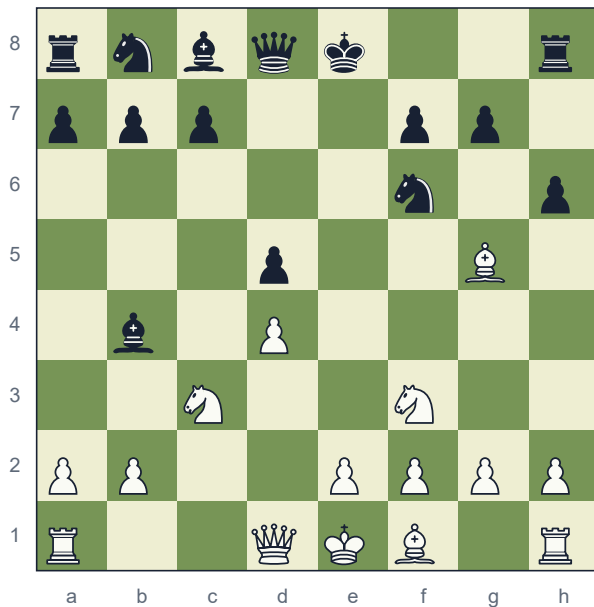
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Ragozin: exchange first

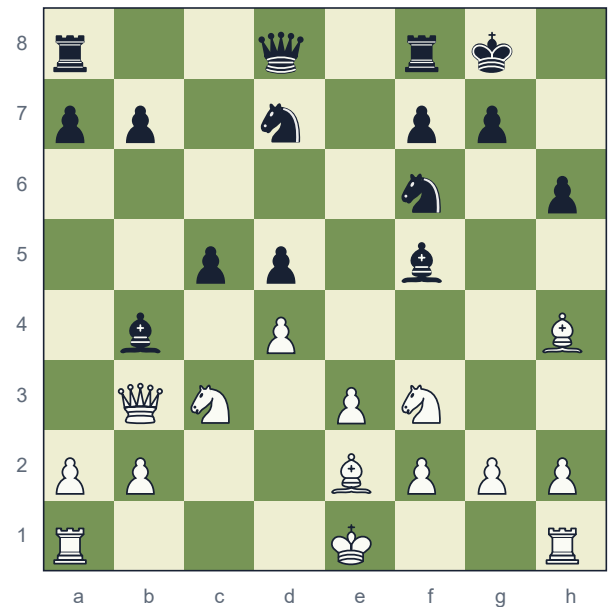
STUDY LINE 03-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 O-O 8. e3 Bf5 9. Be2 Nbd7 10. Qb3 c5

Selected anchor ends with 8. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The exchange removes the tension before the pin generates more complications. Bg5 counter-pins the f6 knight and e3 prepares Bd3.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Bd3 and castle. If ...Bxc3 damages your pawns, compare the bishop pair and central control with the structural cost.

WATCH FOR

Do not forget ...g5 can drive the bishop while ...Ne4 creates central pressure.

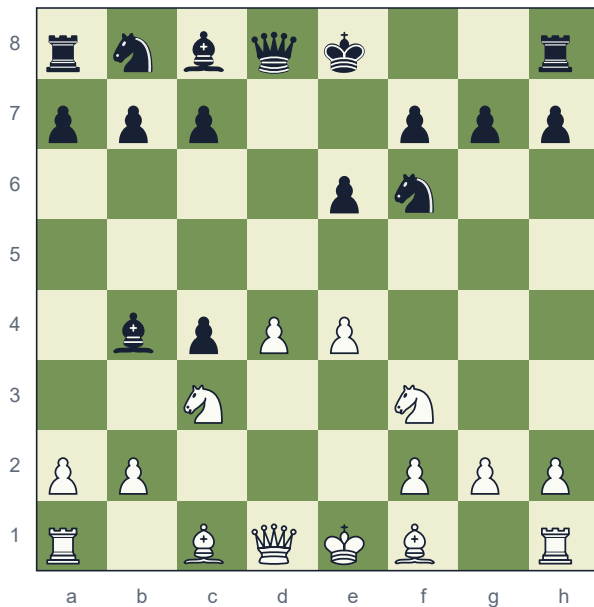
REMEMBER Exchange on d5, then finish development against the pin.

02 Vienna: accept the central invitation

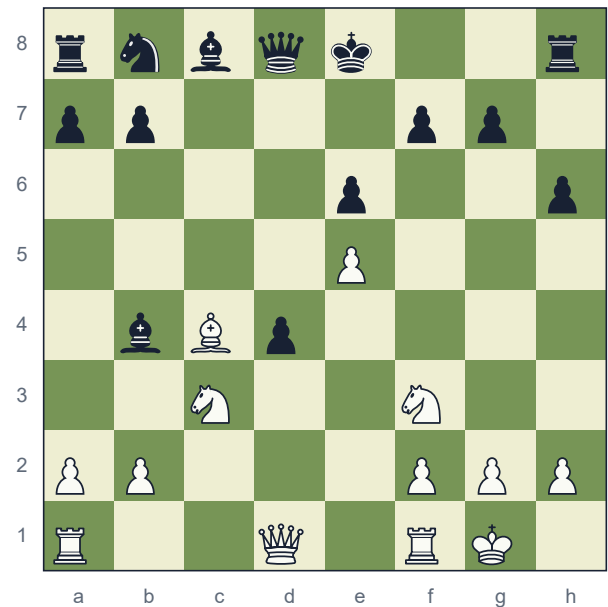
STUDY LINE 03-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bxf6 Qxf6 8. Bxc4 c5 9. O-O cxd4 10. e5 Qd8

Selected anchor ends with 6. Bg5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e4 uses the tempo Black spent capturing c4. The center gives space but becomes the target of ...c5 and ...Nxe4 ideas.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Support the center, develop actively, and calculate before recovering c4. A pawn returned for a lead in development can be a good bargain.

WATCH FOR

The c3 knight may be pinned. Recount e4 defenders after ...Bb4 before treating the pawn as safe.

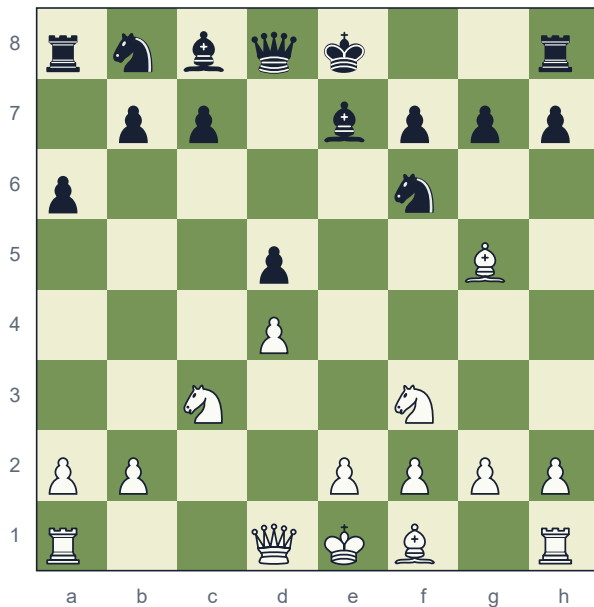
REMEMBER Space creates duties as well as opportunities.

03 Janowski: ...a6

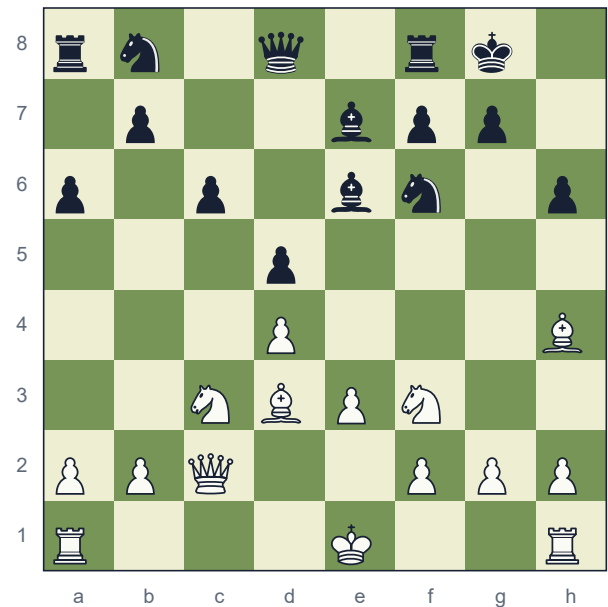
STUDY LINE 03-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 a6 4. Nc3 Nf6 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 Be7 7. e3 h6 8. Bh4 c6 9. Qc2 O-O 10. Bd3 Be6

Selected anchor ends with 7. e3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Black has invested a tempo in ...a6. You can enter an Exchange structure without attempting an immediate punishment.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop and castle. ...a6 may make a later b4-b5 break harder or prepare ...b5, so queenside play needs a fresh calculation.

WATCH FOR

A flank move is not automatically a blunder, and a premature attack can give back your development lead.

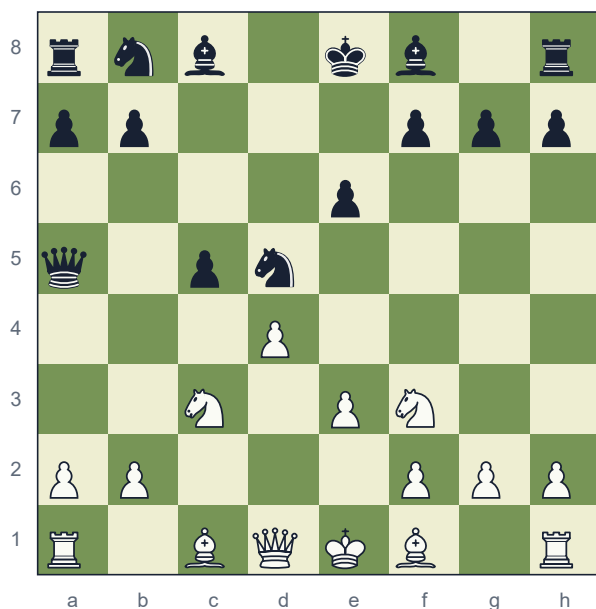
REMEMBER Take the useful center; avoid forcing a refutation.

04 An early queen check on a5

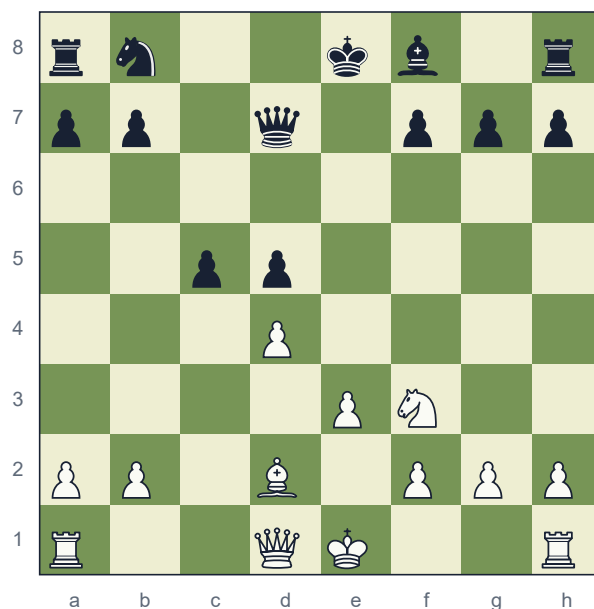
STUDY LINE 03-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e3 Qa5 7. Bd2 Qd8 8. Nxd5 exd5 9. Bb5+ Bd7 10. Bxd7+ Qxd7

Selected anchor ends with 7. Bd2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bd2 unpins the knight and develops a piece. Black's queen sortie gives you a concrete developing response.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bd3 and castling are the priorities. Treat any c-file exchanges as a route into isolated-pawn positions.

WATCH FOR

Do not play a center move that leaves your c3 knight undefended along the a5-e1 diagonal.

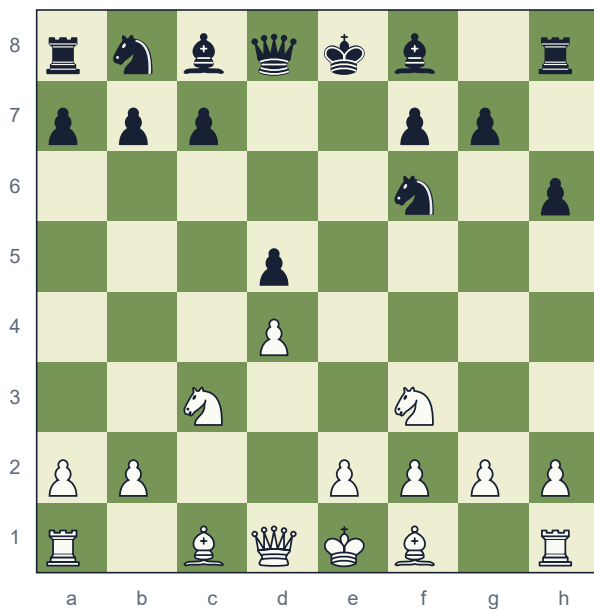
REMEMBER Meet a queen check with useful development.

05 Black plays ...h6 very early

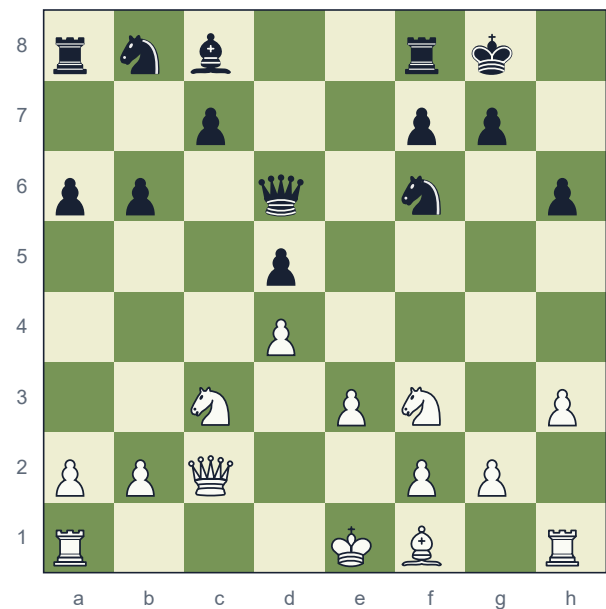
STUDY LINE 03-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 h6 4. Nc3 Nf6 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bf4 Bd6 7. Bxd6 Qxd6 8. Qc2 O-O 9. e3 a6 10. h3 b6

Selected anchor ends with 6. Bf4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Bf4 develops to a useful square without arguing with ...h6. The Exchange structure can still be reached.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e3, Bd3 and O-O. Depending on Black's deployment, place the queen on c2 and coordinate the rooks.

WATCH FOR

Do not spend multiple moves trying to prove that ...h6 was a waste. Your own development is the practical gain.

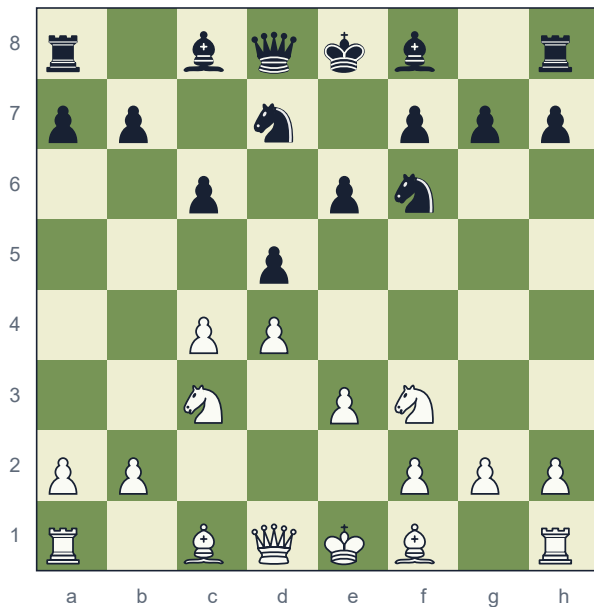
REMEMBER Quiet development can exploit a slow move.

06 Triangle move order: choose e3 before Nc3

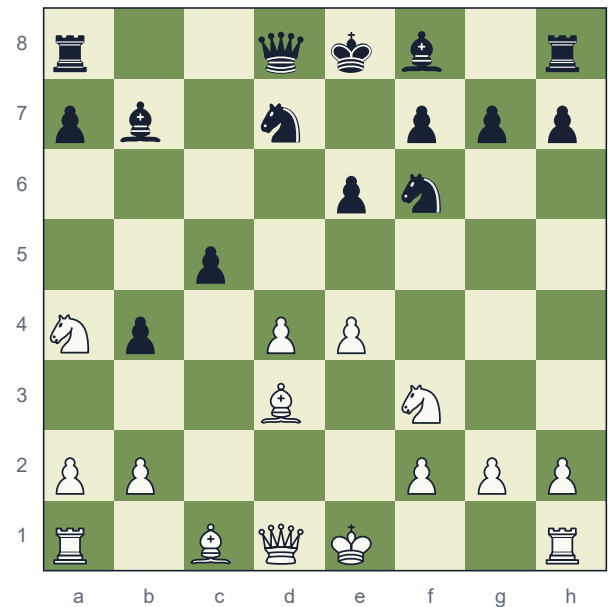
STUDY LINE 03-06

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c6 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 Bb7 9. e4 b4 10. Na4 c5

Selected anchor ends with 6. Bd3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

With ...e6 and ...c6 already played, e3 prepares to recover c4 without entering a Noteboom pawn-grab line with the b1 knight committed too early.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

If Black develops ...Nf6, return to the e3 Semi-Slav. If ...dxc4 comes first, recover with Bxc4 and watch ...b5.

WATCH FOR

Playing Nc3 automatically against the triangle allows ...dxc4 and a different body of theory.

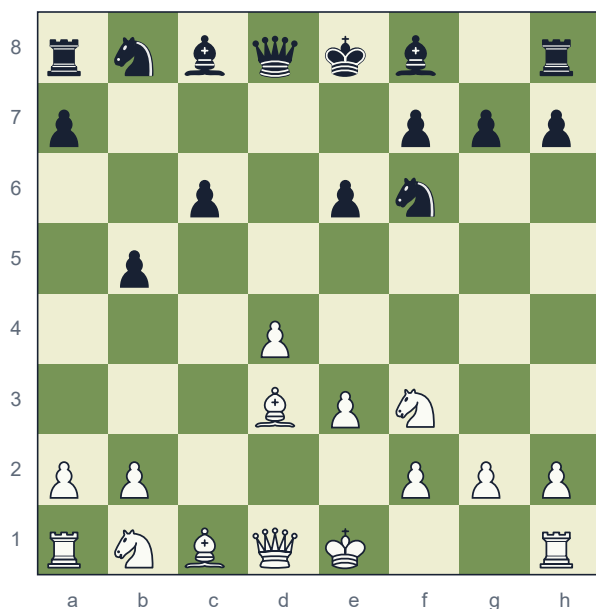
REMEMBER Against the triangle, e3 is the practical bridge.

07 Triangle: Black takes on c4 immediately

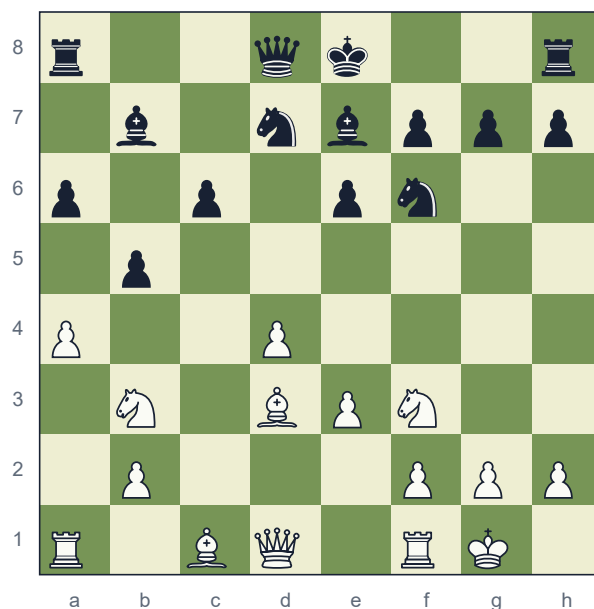
STUDY LINE 03-07

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 c6 4. e3 dxc4 5. Bxc4 b5 6. Bd3 Nf6 7. O-O a6 8. a4 Bb7 9. Nbd2 Nbd7 10. Nb3 Be7

Selected anchor ends with 7. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The e3 pawn move allowed a clean bishop recapture. Black can still expand, but White develops toward a central response.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

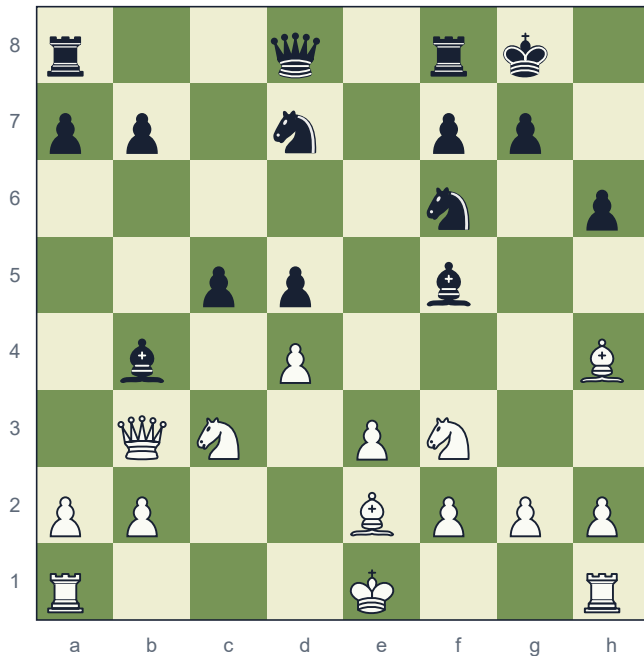
Develop the b1 knight and prepare e4 when ready. This is related to the Semi-Slav structures in Booklet 06.

WATCH FOR

Remember to retreat the bishop when ...b5 attacks it.

REMEMBER Recover c4 with development and keep the center flexible.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

These variations can produce a Carlsbad, an isolated queen pawn, or a broad e4-d4 center. The pawn skeleton must guide your choice, not the opening name.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

...Bb4 pins Nc3; ...dxc4 can invite e4 and attack the new center; ...a6 prepares ...b5 or asks a useful waiting question.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop Bd3 and castle. If ...Bxc3 damages your pawns, compare the bishop pair and central control with the structural cost.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.